Write a scope management plan

30 minutes · teams of 4 to 6 · template on pages 2 to 5

A scope management plan says what a project will deliver, what it won't, and how changes get dealt with. Thirty minutes won't give you a finished one. You'll get a rough draft and you'll find out which parts are weak, which is the point.

The project

Harbour Physio is a clinic with five physiotherapists and one receptionist. Every appointment is made by phone and written in a paper diary, and double bookings happen most weeks. The owner wants an online booking system. Patients book, change and cancel their own appointments and get a text reminder the day before. The receptionist sees one calendar for everyone, and each physio sees their own day.

The owner has 12 weeks and NZ$25,000, and wants it running before winter. Online payments and patient notes have both come up as "maybe later". Your team is the project team. Deciding what those two mean for your plan is part of the job.

If you'd rather plan a real project one of you has worked on, that's fine, as long as everyone knows it well enough to answer questions about it.

The 30 minutes

0 to 4	Read the project. Agree a two-sentence summary for section 1. Pick a project manager, who also keeps time.
4 to 5	Split the sections between you (below).
5 to 17	Write your own section, quietly. Rough is fine, and short lists beat paragraphs.
17 to 25	Swap with a teammate and read theirs. Run the four checks below.
25 to 28	Fix what the checks turned up. The project manager fills in the top of page 2 and the sign-off.
28 to 30	Get ready to tell the class one thing you left out on purpose, and why.

Who writes what

Five people shown. With four, one person takes sections 2, 3, 6 and 7. With six, two people share the WBS.

Person 1	Sections 2 and 3: how scope is managed, and who does what
Person 2	Section 4, first half: description, deliverables, acceptance criteria
Person 3	Section 4, second half: exclusions, constraints, assumptions
Person 4	Section 5: the work breakdown structure and dictionary
Person 5	Sections 6 and 7: checking the work, and handling changes

The four checks

For minutes 17 to 25. Ask these about your teammate's section, not your own.

1. Does every deliverable show up in the WBS, and does every WBS item lead to a deliverable?
2. Could a stranger answer yes or no to each acceptance criterion? "Easy to use" can't be answered. "A patient can book without phoning the clinic" can.
3. Is each exclusion something a reasonable person might have expected to be included? "Anything not listed" doesn't count. Look at what you did with online payments and patient notes.
4. Does the change process name one person who decides, and say how long they have?

Scope management plan

PROJECT NAME	TEAM	DATE

1 Project summary

Two or three sentences: what is being built, for whom, and why.

2 How scope will be managed

Short answers. One name per question is better than "the team".

Who is responsible for managing scope?

Where is the scope written down? (scope statement, WBS, dictionary)

How will we check the work against the scope?

Who accepts the finished project?

3 Roles and responsibilities

Everyone on the project, sponsor included. Say what each person does about scope, not their whole job.

NAME	ROLE	WHAT THEY DO ABOUT SCOPE

4 Scope statement

4a Description

What the project will produce, in a short paragraph.

4b Deliverables

A list. Each one is something you could hand over or point to.

4c Acceptance criteria

For each deliverable, what has to be true before it counts as done. Write each one so someone else can answer yes or no.

4d Exclusions

Things someone might reasonably expect that are not part of this project. Be specific.

4e Constraints

Limits on time, money, people and equipment.

4f Assumptions

Things you're treating as true but haven't confirmed. If one turns out wrong, the plan changes.

5 Work breakdown structure

5a WBS outline

Break each deliverable into smaller pieces until you reach work packages: pieces of work one person could finish in about a week. As a guide, no more than 40 hours each. Number the levels 1, 1.1, 1.1.1.

5b WBS dictionary

One row per work package. Anyone picking up the row should know what to do and what to hand back.

CODE	WORK PACKAGE	WHAT THE WORK INVOLVES	DELIVERABLE	OWNER	ESTIMATE

Checking and changing the scope

6 Scope verification

How each deliverable gets checked against the scope and formally accepted. Do it as each one is finished, not once at the end.

7 Scope control and changes

What happens when someone wants something added, removed or different.

Who can ask for a change, and how do they ask?

Who works out the effect on time, cost and quality?

Who decides, and how long do they have?

How is everyone told, and which documents get updated?

8 Sign-off

Approved by the project sponsor.

NAME	TITLE	DATE

Signature